

QUEER IN PUBLIC. QUEER IN COLLAPSE.

written and produced by chris armstrong



a zine for refusing capture and a homage to
What's Queer About Queer Studies Now
Parable of the Sower and
Femme in Public

A ZINE. A REASON. A RECKONING.

Not a citation parade.
Not a paper pinned flat beneath pressure
but rather
A stapled stack of shared breath.
A zine that smudges, that softens at the
corners from being passed hand to hand.

Space is made, not granted.
Knowledge is grown, not gated.
It roots in story. It ripens in relationship.
It holds theory. It holds space

Memory lives here.
Hums beneath the text.
Survival has a sound, a steady undercurrent.
Counted in what was endured, what was lost,
what was remade.

Poetry is not ornament.
Not lace draped over logic.
It is proof pressed into the page.

Audience is not assumed.
Reader is not defaulted.
Learning is not linear.

The zine form folds scholarship into
something held.
Creased. Carried. Dog-eared. Dialogue.
Scholarship becomes tactile.
Ink becomes invitation.
Theory becomes touch.

Cisheteronormativity shrinks under scrutiny.
Its scripts stutter when read aloud.
Its assumptions thin when named.

Decolonizing knowledge
by making community the method

Breaking free of
tower talk
normative narratives
whiteness as unquestioned frame

Whiteness is a distortion
we interrupt in community
we unlearn in practice

Rooted in Queer and Trans Theory.
Rooted in public scholarship.
Rooted in community-based research.
Refuses to pathologize trans lives.
Refuses deficit narratives.

Trans lives are not case studies.
Not citations.
Not cautionary tales.

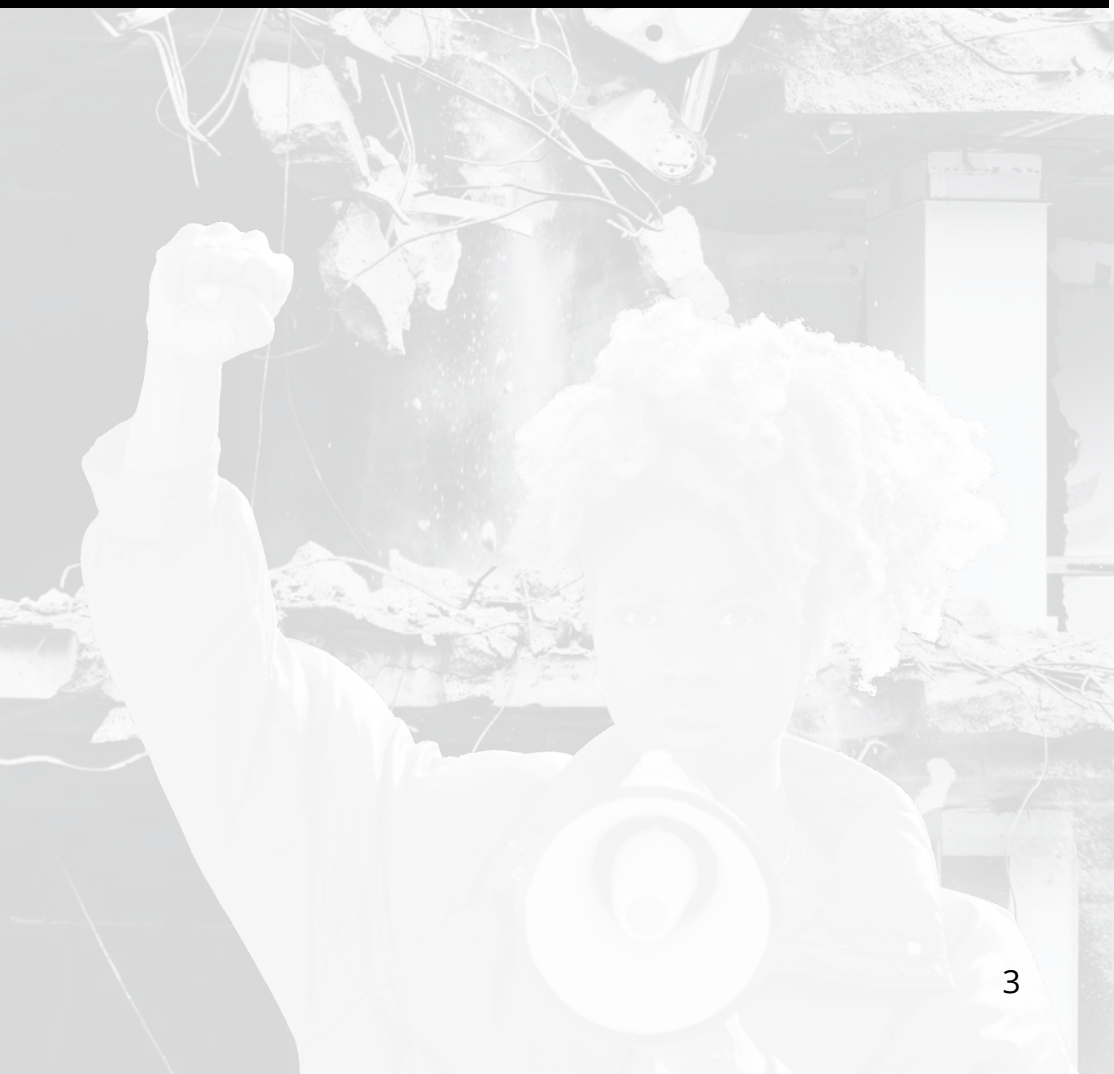
They are knowledge in motion.
They are method made flesh.
They are curriculum carried in
community.
They trouble tidy theories.
They reshape what counts as credible.
They are not subjects of debate.
They are sources.
They are scholars of their own survival.

For trans and nonbinary people
too often studied, diminished, distilled
Not objects.
Not outsiders.
Not the footnote

Rather they are the authors.
The editors.
The archivists of their own becoming.



COMFORT IS HOW POWER SURVIVES.
QUEER STUDIES DOES NOT EXIST
TO SOOTHE INSTITUTIONS
OR SMOOTH THEIR EDGES.
IT EXISTS BECAUSE
EVERY COMFORT IS PURCHASED
WITH SOMEONE ELSE'S ERASURE.





QUEER IS A POSITION, NOT A DESCRIPTION

Queer does not knock.
Queer does not wait its turn.
Queer does not come to be
included.

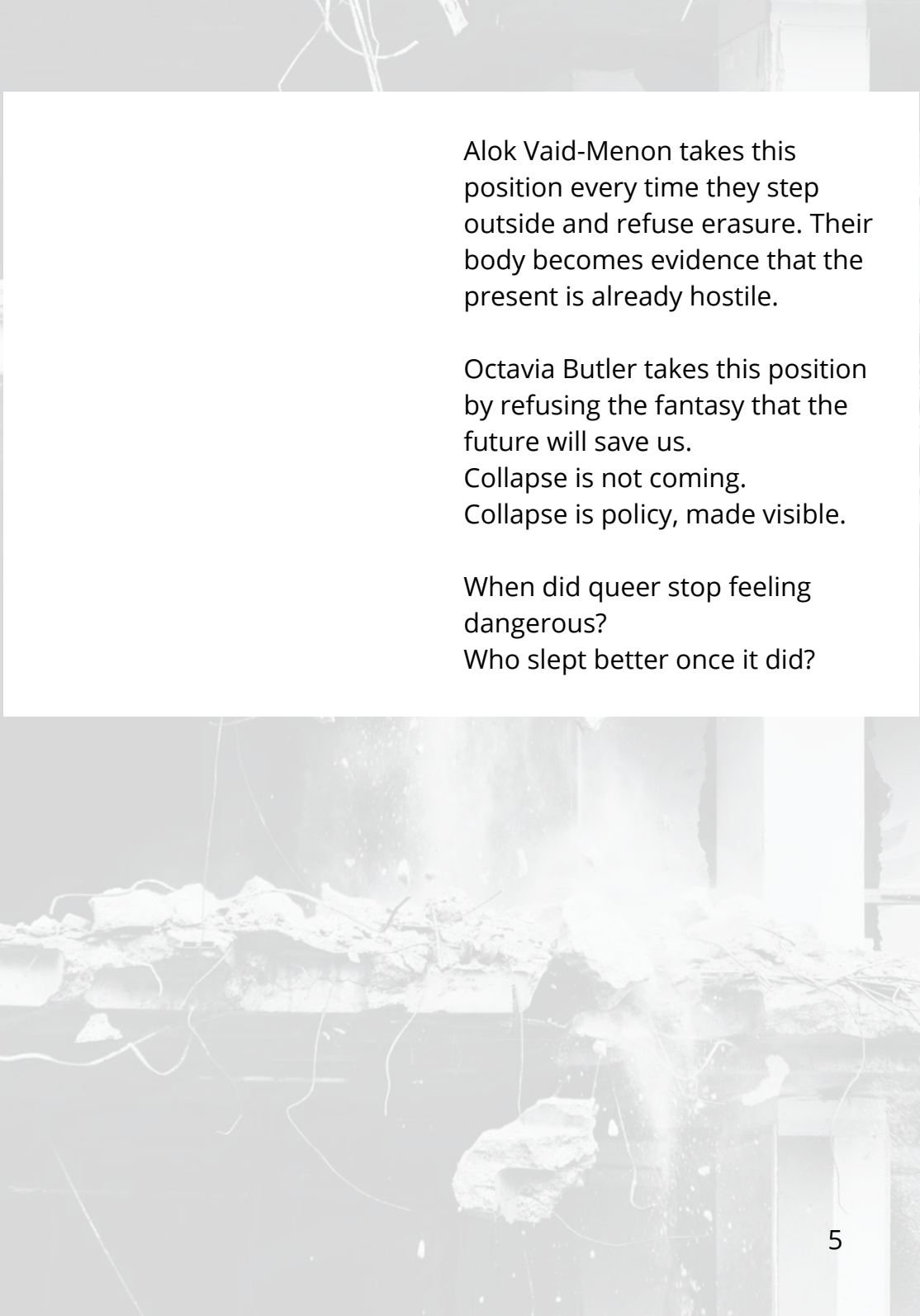
Queer does not come to be
understood.

Queer does not come to be
respectable.

Queer came to interrupt.
It interrupts
the lie of gender binaries
the neatness of sexual
categories
the sanctity of the nuclear family
the borders of nationhood
the quiet acceptance of who
counts as human

Queer studies does not
catalogue identities like artifacts.
It chooses sides. It takes a
position against the world that
treats survival as a privilege
instead of a right.

interrupt



Alok Vaid-Menon takes this position every time they step outside and refuse erasure. Their body becomes evidence that the present is already hostile.

Octavia Butler takes this position by refusing the fantasy that the future will save us.

Collapse is not coming.

Collapse is policy, made visible.

When did queer stop feeling dangerous?

Who slept better once it did?



”

What would change if “queer” was treated as a stance against the world rather than a trait?

Which interruptions named here feel most threatening to power today, and why?

“

QUEER IS NOT AN IDENTITY BADGE

Queer is not a personality trait.
Queer is not branding.
Queer is not a checkbox on a form.
Queer is not only about desire.
Queer is a practice of refusal.

Queer keeps asking:
Who does this benefit?
Who decided this was normal?
Who gets punished for deviation?
Who disappears quietly,
without headlines or memorials?

Normal is not descriptive.
Normal is enforced.
Normal decides
whose gender is legible
whose families are legitimate
whose pain is intelligible
whose suffering is negligible

Legible

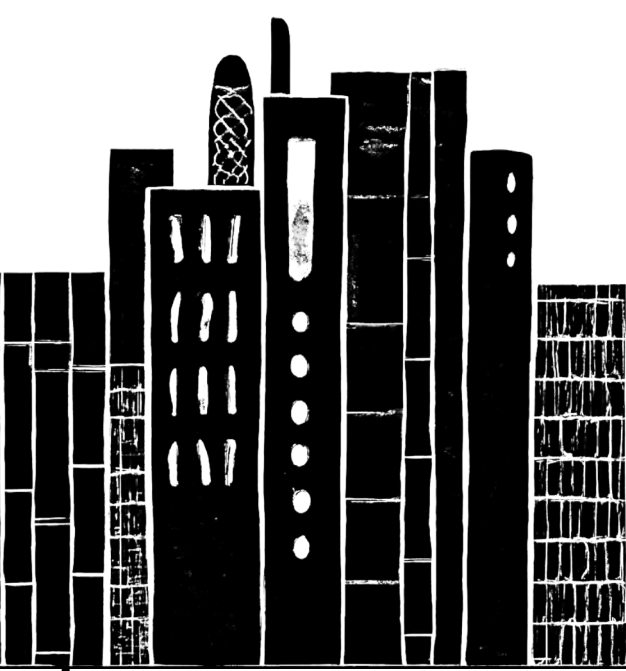


Alok shows how femininity, when it escapes control, is treated like public property: available for commentary, correction, threat.

Butler shows how poverty, race, and disposability determine who is abandoned when systems fracture.

When queer becomes a label instead of a weapon, power exhales.

Do you use queer to name yourself, or to confront systems?
What happens when you stop explaining?



”

Where has “normal”
been enforced in your
life under the guise of
neutrality?

When has queerness
functioned as a shield
rather than a tool of
confrontation?

“

NORMALIZATION IS A SLOW VIOLENCE

Normalization kills slowly.

It does not always strike.

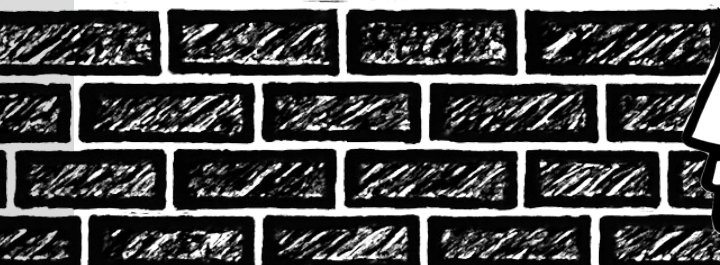
It schedules you.

It organizes your life
until resistance feels impractical,
until refusal feels irresponsible.

Normalization decides:
whose relationships "mature."
whose lives count as successful
whose grief is legitimate
whose time is wasted

Queer studies refuses theory
that floats above consequence.

The body is where violence lands.
The body is where policy becomes
pain.





”

How has normalization structured your sense of time or success?

Where does violence land on the body before it is ever named as policy?

“

Alok's work traces how surveillance, staring, harassment
accumulate in muscle and nerve
This is not metaphor, this is memory stored in flesh

Butler's hyperempathy insists that feeling is not weakness
It is intelligence, it is data about a world in crisis

Queer studies learns from both
If your theory cannot survive the body, it cannot survive at all





NORMALIZATION REWARDS COMPLIANCE

Normalization does not only exclude.
It recruits

It whispers
"You're one of the good ones"
"You belong"
"You're safe now"
The safety fades away

Queer studies defends people
not categories

Butler shows how shared identity
does not dissolve hierarchy
Power reproduces itself
unless challenged

Alok shows that polish
does not equal protection
Even perfect performance
cannot shield femme

What did you surrender to be legible?
Who was never allowed to make that
bargain?

Solidarity is not assumed
It is built



”

What did you surrender
to be legible?

Who was never offered
the bargain of legibility?

How does compliance
reproduce hierarchy
even within shared
identity?

“

QUEER TIME IS EMERGENCY TIME

Queer liberalism promises
rights
recognition
representation

But it demands
respectability
obedience
allegiance

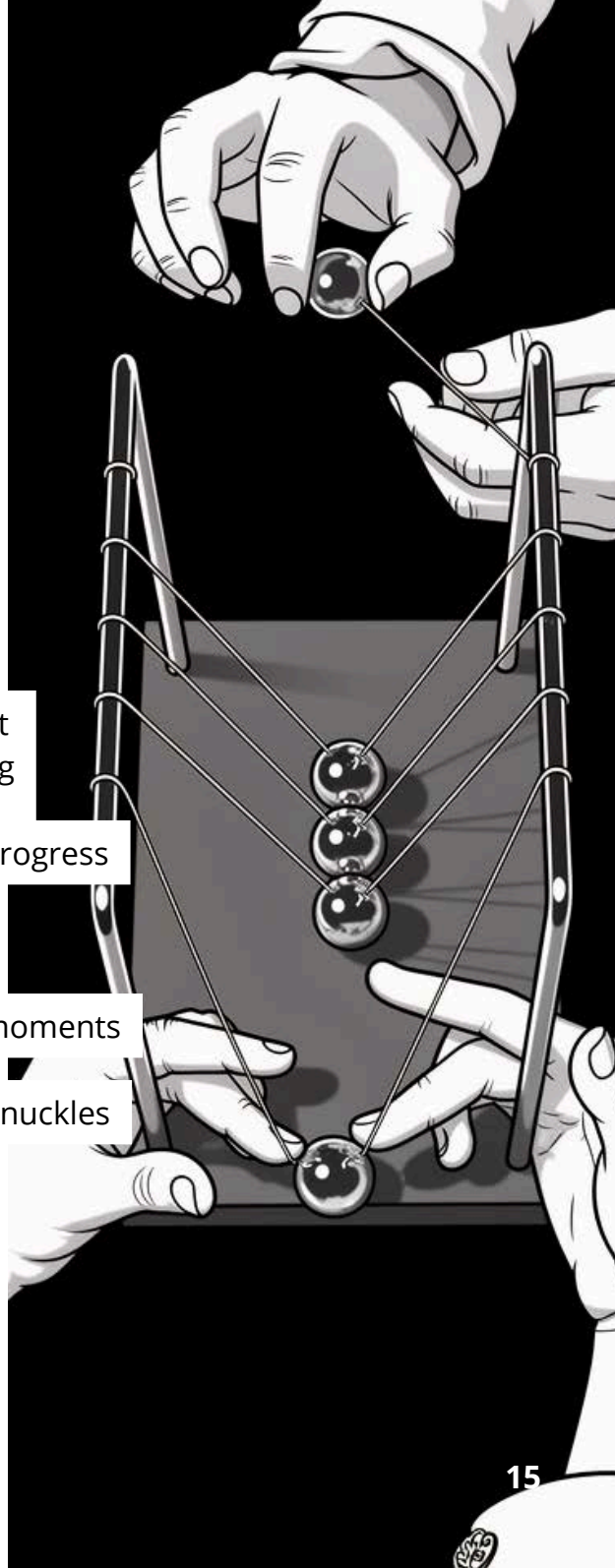
It says
You may stay
as long as you do not disrupt
Inclusion becomes the ceiling

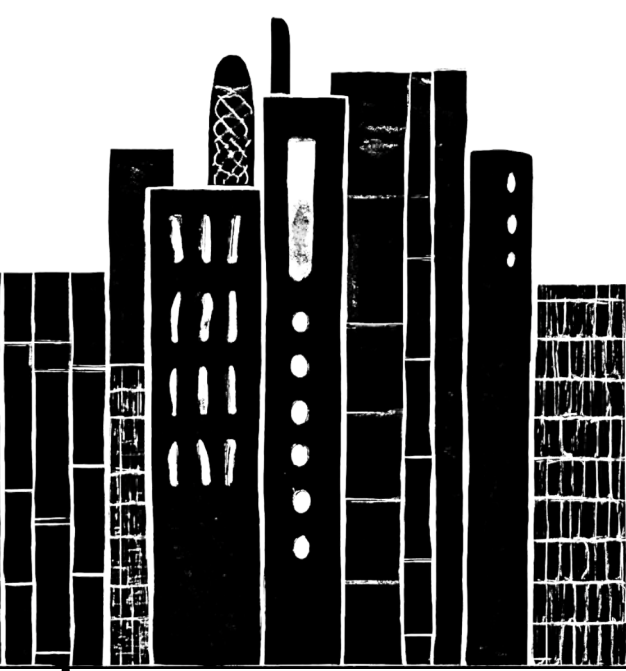
Queer studies reject linear progress
There is no snooze button
for those under threat

Alok writes from stretched moments
the breath before the slur
the keys threaded through knuckles

Butler writes from a future
that has already arrived
for the poor
the racialized
the disposable

Urgency is not chaos
it is clarity under pressure





”

What emergencies are
hidden by linear
narratives of progress?

Who is denied the luxury
of patience?

“



PUBLIC SPACE IS ENFORCED SPACE

Lucidity does not deflect bullets
Visibility does not deter deportation

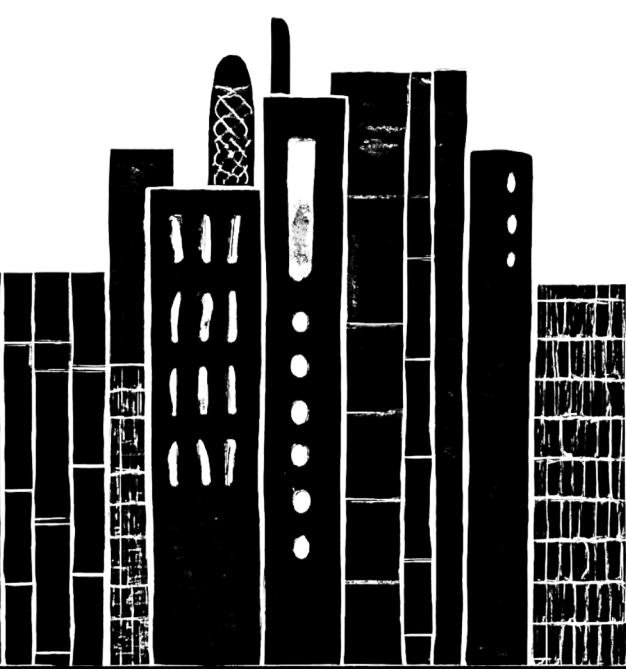
You can be
seen and sentenced
still and silenced
"That's fine, dude. I'm not mad at
you."

Public space is not neutral
It is regulated, surveilled & enforced

Alok illustrates
how fear is framed as
feminine responsibility
how threat is socialized
how denial stays clean

Butler shows how land,
housing, and borders do
the same work at scale

Rights are written
Safety is shared



”

What violences are justified by calling fear an individual responsibility?

How do land, housing, and borders perform the same enforcement as policing?

“

RESPECTABILITY PROTECTS SYSTEMS, NOT PEOPLE

The nation celebrates queers who:
consume
serve
salute

Queer freedom becomes evidence
of a country's claimed conscience

The compliant fall beside the defiant.

Alok shows how politeness
fails to interrupt violence
and often accelerates it

Butler shows how obedience
does not prevent abandonment

Queer studies rejects respectability
it stabilizes systems,
it destabilizes lives.





”

How does the nation use queer inclusion to narrate its own morality?

What forms of obedience are celebrated as freedom?

“



WE RISE TOGETHER.
WE FALL TOGETHER.

Empire does not reject queerness
It weaponizes it

Those who will not disrupt
Those who will not demand
Those who will not remember

Good queers are
clean
contained
convenient

Bad queers are
raw
radicalized
resistant

Queer studies is anti-individualism
because survival was never solo

Butler teaches that survival is
shared labor
shared learning
shared risk

Alok shows how isolation is engineered
so brutality becomes biography

Mutual aid is not charity
Chosen family is infrastructure



”

How is isolation engineered to turn systemic harm into personal failure?

What kinds of labor make survival collective rather than individual?

“

**QUEER SPACE.
LIBERATION SPACE.
COMPLICIT SPACE**

Queer space is not the same as
liberated space.

It still
mirrors the nation
rewards respectability
protects power
centers whiteness
punishes poverty
polices language

Queer studies does not promise
comfort
it names complicity.

Earthseed teaches survival through
adaptation
as collective ethic.

Change is constant.
Complacency is lethal.

Alok's joy is not naïveté.
It is strategy against despair.

Queer futurity is labor,
not longing.





Where does queer space reproduce the logics of the nation?

What becomes easiest to ignore when comfort is prioritized?

How can joy function as strategy rather than escape?



QUEER KNOWLEDGE MUST MOVE

Queer studies can still
press resistance into credentials,
polish bruises until they shine like
theory
while accountability waits, uninvited,

Knowledge locked tight
does not rest.
It grows rigid.
Power paused in place.

In Parable of the Sower,
literacy is a lifeline.

In Femme in Public,
language breaks the training:
swallow the pain,
survive by renaming it strength.

Queer studies should not stand still.
It should flow through.

Knowledge that moves through rooms,
through bodies,
through translation after translation
until it can protect,
until it can intervene,
until it can exist beyond the page.



”

What happens when
knowledge is hoarded
instead of circulated?

Who is denied
protection when theory
stays on the page?

“

VIOLENCE IS STRUCTURAL, NOT EXCEPTIONAL

Race, gender, sex, class, disability,
nation

do not assemble neatly

They collide

They compound vulnerability

What happens to Alok repeats

because repetition is the design

Harassment is the choreography

Butler did not collapse by chance

Policy held the hand that pushed

Intersectionality is not symmetry.

It is fragility.





”

Where have you experienced repetition not as coincidence, but as structure?

What policies made harm predictable in your life?

“



QUEER TIME RESISTS PRODUCTIVITY

The state keeps a ledger
growth recorded,
pairing approved,
labor extracted,
death understated.

Queer studies is not a war on belief.
It is a refusal to kneel.

Butler reimagines God as change itself,
unfixing what claims permanence.

Alok frames self-love
as shared resistance
to erasure.

Queer time allows
for grief that interrupts,
for care that slows,
for living on.

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QUEER JOY AS SURVIVAL

Joy is not ambient.
It is survival as radiance.

Alok stays present, incandescent,
in a world that punishes
illumination.

Butler fractures the illusion of
dusk, refuses the easing dark.

Queer studies is not brightness
for display. it is rupture.



”

When has joy functioned
as survival rather than
celebration?

What forms of radiance
are punished as excess?

“

belonging

BELONGING AND THEORY IN MOTION

Diaspora shatters the fantasy of a single beginning.
belonging loosens
becomes conditional
breakable

Queer studies refuses canon as cage

Alok is not a case study
They are theory in motion

Butler is not a genre
She writes survival into philosophy



”

What does it mean to
live theory rather
than cite it?

How does survival
rewrite philosophy?

“



HOSTILITY HUMS

Queer studies lives
between hostility humming in
daylight
and horizons shaped by disaster

One names the flames
The other names the spark

Queer is not resolution
Queer is refusal

So pause and ask
what norms will you break
when the price is
safety
recognition
belonging?

Fold this
Share it anyway
Let it circulate





”

What norms feel hardest to break because they promise safety?

What does refusal cost you right now?

Who taught you which risks were acceptable?

safe



QUEER CALLS TO ACTION

Queer weakens when it is made legible
Refuse the safety of respectability
Center those already paying the cost
Sever the path
from recognition to domination
Work toward material change
not decorative progress
Keep queer unsettled

Read Alok Vaid-Menon
as queer theory in motion

CALL TO ACTION 1: REFUSE RESPECTABILITY

Stop organizing around what is palatable to power.
Respectability is a sedative:
it promises safety and delivers silence.

It trains queer people to
temper tone,
tidy rage,
discipline bodies,

It rewards restraint
and reprimands urgency.

Refusal means:

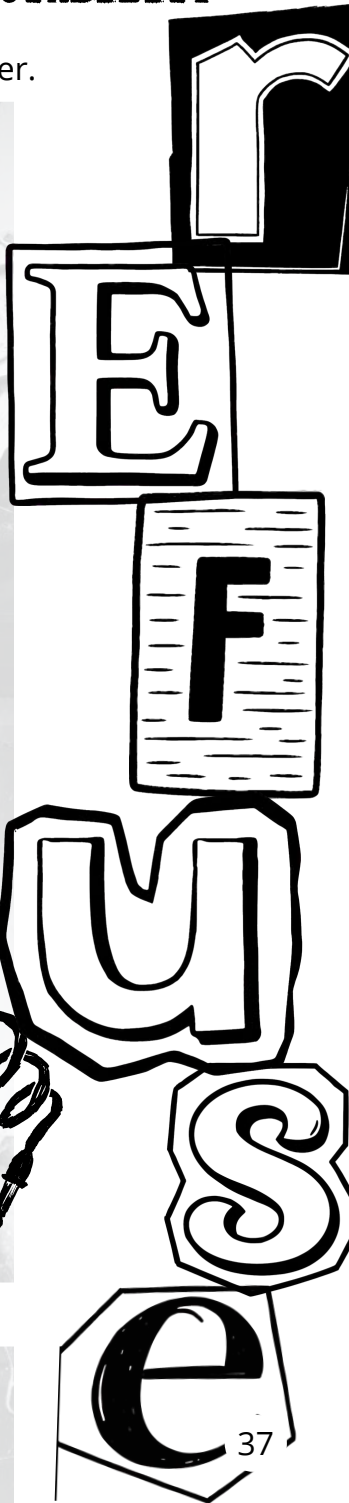
Defending those labeled
too angry, too loud, too much, bad for optics

Naming civility when it is used
to stall justice

Refusing to grind rage
into digestible soundbites

Organizing practice:
When someone says,
"This will hurt our credibility," ask:
Credible to whom?
At whose expense?
Who is being asked to shrink so others feel safe?

Refuse the silence.
Refuse the smallness.
Refuse respectability.





”

Who benefits when
credibility becomes
the goal?

Who is asked to shrink
so movements can
appear reasonable?

“

CALL TO ACTION 2: CENTER THOSE MOST AT RISK

Never organize around comfort
Comfort collapses under strain

Center those under pressure
undocumented, incarcerated, disabled
poor, unhoused, trans
racialized and exposed to violence

Centering is not representation
It is redistribution of power

Let those most targeted
set direction
determine tempo
define safety
name acceptable risk

This will slow timelines
Strain explanations
Disturb institutions
Good

Organizing practice
If they are not present, pause
Silence is a signal
Listen
Change the landscape



”

Who is missing from
your organizing spaces,
and why?

What barriers are
treated as incidental
rather than structural?

How would pace change
if survival set the tempo?

“

CALL TO ACTION 3: REFUSE RULE THROUGH RECOGNITION

Reject queer politics that reinforce rule through recognition.

It has been built to
stretch surveillance,
sanitize separation,
smooth incarceration,
style war,
sell violence as progress.

Refusal means:

Walking away from recognition
that demands silence

Questioning victories
that grant access without redistribution

Refusing progress
that renders others disposable

Queer liberation cannot be delivered
by institutions designed to detain

Organizing practice:
Audit your demands. Ask
Do they widen the state's reach?
Or narrow its ability to wound?
Refuse the former.





”

Where has inclusion strengthened the systems you oppose?

What kinds of progress leave carceral power intact?

“

CHANGE

CALL TO ACTION 4: ORGANIZE FOR CHANGE

Being seen is not being safe.
Being praised is not being protected

Visibility can invite violence
as easily as care

Fight for material ground:
housing, health, income, land,
bodily autonomy,
freedom from cages and surveillance

Symbols are leverage, not liberation.

If success does not ease hunger,
housing, or harm, it is hollow.

Question every campaign:
what shifts in lived reality?





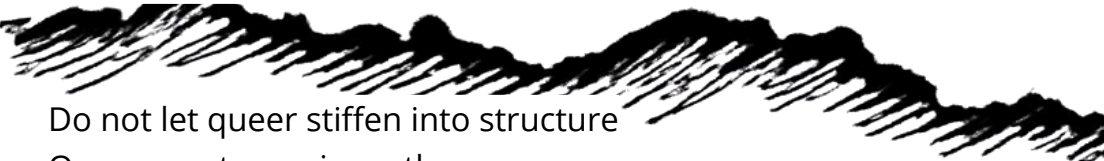
What would materially change if your advocacy succeeded?

What forms of visibility increase risk rather than reduce it?

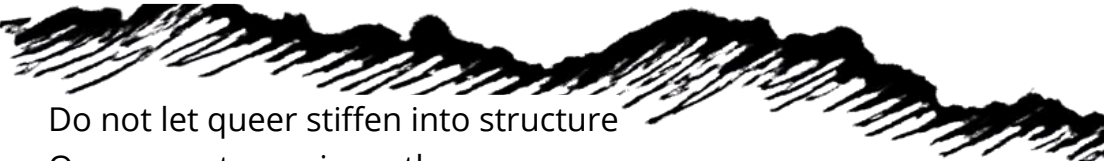
How do you measure success beyond symbolism?



CALL TO ACTION 5: KEEP QUEER UNSETTLED

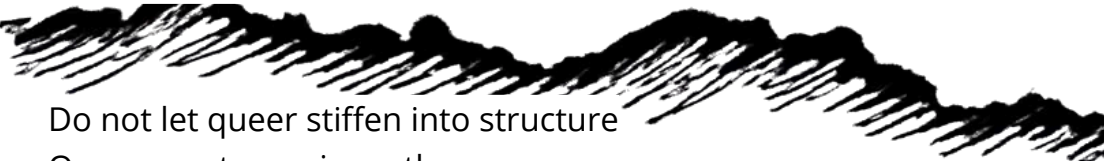


Do not let queer stiffen into structure
Queer must remain restless
rough around the edges



Refusal also means refusing ourselves
when unity is weaponized
when dissent is dismissed as disloyalty
when critique is a contagion

A togetherness that cannot
tolerate tension
is not solidarity.
It is containment.



Queer studies, queer organizing,
queer futures must refuse stillness,
fracture their own frameworks,
question their comforts,
or become bureaucracy
fluent in liberation.

Organizing practice:
Build moments into the work
where anyone can ask
Who is being silenced?
Whose needs are being deferred?
What truths have become
inconvenient?
Let these questions interrupt.
Let them redirect.

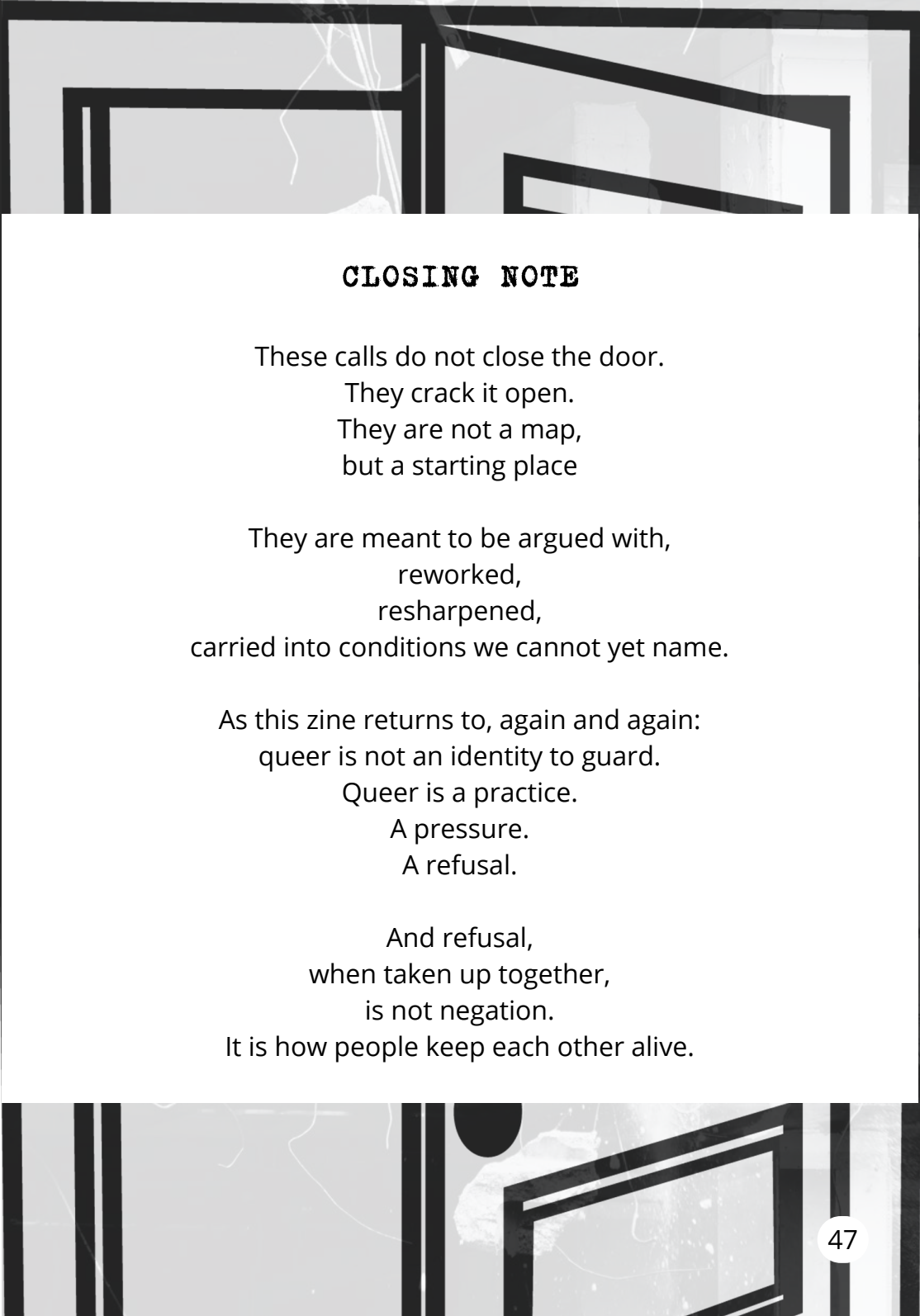


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What tensions are
being smoothed over
in the name of unity?

What has become too
comfortable to
question?

“



CLOSING NOTE

These calls do not close the door.
They crack it open.
They are not a map,
but a starting place

They are meant to be argued with,
reworked,
resharpened,
carried into conditions we cannot yet name.

As this zine returns to, again and again:
queer is not an identity to guard.
Queer is a practice.
A pressure.
A refusal.

And refusal,
when taken up together,
is not negation.
It is how people keep each other alive.



”

How will you carry these calls into conditions not yet named?

What does collective refusal look like where you live?

“